

Down Police Lane

WEST BENGAL

Bihar

KOLKATA

Orissa

With artefacts from 1704 to the American Center attacks of 2002 on display, a museum in Kolkata showcases the evolution of the police over centuries



SOUVASHIS MULLICK

VISITORS TAKE A LOOK AT THE WEAPONS ON DISPLAY

By Elora Sen

A beggar in distress trying to reach a hospital from Strand Road had to wait two days before a policeman took note of the problem, resulting in an official memo to Calcutta policemen that they should be more sensitive towards citizens. The memo of October 9, 1902 was sent by then commissioner of police RA D'o Rignell. Not much may have changed, but the Kolkata Police has added a feather to its cap by maintaining a police museum, documenting its history and highlighting present day activities.

A unique concept, the museum is housed in an imposing red building which was earlier the residence of Raja Ram Mohan Roy. Inaugurated on August 31, 1996, it underwent renovation in 2007 and is spread over two floors, with six galleries housing artifacts all the way back from 1704—ever since the police was conceptualised as a watch-and-ward unit. The history of India's freedom struggle finds pride of place—almost ironical from the perspective that the police were actually against the freedom fighters. A four-ft 30-kg wooden club seized in 1908 from Shivaji Club, Jhamapukur, is

reputed to have been used by club members, including freedom fighters, for exercise. Today, not many would be able to lift the club. Other interesting pieces include a book bomb that was sent to D.H. Kingsford, chief presidency magistrate, Calcutta, in an unsuccessful attempt to eliminate him in 1908; damaged parts of a vehicle belonging to Charles Tegart, the commissioner of police, who escaped a bid on his life in 1930 and the weapons surrendered before Mahatma Gandhi in Belegghata in 1947. An unexploded Japanese bomb that was dropped on the city during World War II is also preserved here.

Among the more recent items showcased in the museum are the arms used during the terror attack on the American Center in 2002. Activities of the police force—the Detective Department, the Police Training School, the Mounted Police—are archived here and the evolution of the force is well documented. One can't help but smile reading another official memo—written by J. Lambert (deputy commissioner) in 1878 which warns the public against violation of traffic rules and to keep within speed limits. Well, not much has changed on that front either. ■